NEXT LEVEL HORSE BUSINESSES

Horse-First Profit *Architecture*

How to build a riding school that's good for horses, good for families, and finally good to you.

Brian Sean Wee

CFP · EA · FOR RIDING SCHOOLS

Horse-First Profit Architecture for Riding Schools

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A note on the financial chapter. Brian Sean Wee is a CERTIFIED FINANCIAL PLANNER™ professional and an IRS Enrolled Agent. Even so, the financial, tax, legal, and insurance material in this book is general education, not individualized advice. Every barn is different. Before you act on the entity, insurance, tax, or wealth-building ideas here, work them through with your own qualified advisors.

The illustrative figures in this book — lesson prices, horse hours, monthly revenue — are round numbers chosen to teach the model clearly. Your numbers are yours to find.

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A Letter Before *We Begin*

If you own or run a riding school, I wrote this for you — especially if you love the horses and the work, and you are quietly tired and quietly broke.

I have spent my career inside this industry, helping riding schools become as profitable as they are good. Through my company, Next Level Horse Businesses, my team and I have worked with more than a thousand of them. I am also a CERTIFIED FINANCIAL PLANNER™ professional and an Enrolled Agent — which is a long way of saying I am held to a fiduciary standard with money and I am credentialed by the IRS on tax. I tell you that not to impress you, but so you know that when we get to the chapters on pricing, protection, and wealth, I am not guessing.

Here is the one idea this whole book is built on, and it is the one most people in our world get backwards:

> ***A riding school can be horse-first and profitable. Not one or the other. Each one requires the other.***

An unprofitable barn cannot truly care for its horses — it cuts the farrier visit, stretches the feed, skips the vet, and works the old campaigner one more season because it can't afford to retire him. And a barn that abuses its capacity and its owner — the one running seven days a week for no take-home pay — does not last long enough to care for anything. Profit is not the enemy of the horse. Profit is what protects the horse. It is also what protects your family, your marriage, and the years of your life you are pouring into this.

What follows is a method, not a pep talk. We will rebuild your business in roughly the order I would rebuild it if I were standing in your barn aisle: the welfare floor first, then the way the horses earn their living, then your pricing, your market, your schedule, your numbers, the way you fill your lessons, and finally how you keep and grow what you make. Read it in order. It compounds.

You are my kind of person — someone trying to build something good and have it pay. Let's get to work.

— Brian Sean Wee, CFP, EA

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CHAPTER ONE

The Lie That's Quietly *Killing Riding Schools*

"You can't make money with horses." It is the most expensive sentence in our industry, and almost everyone believes it.

I have heard it in a hundred barn aisles, usually from someone wonderful. She is a gifted instructor. Her horses are kind and her students adore her. She teaches seven days a week, hasn't taken a real day off in years, and undercharges so badly that a full hour of her expertise costs less than a haircut. Clients pay in cash, checks, and apologies. Some go months owing money she is too gracious to chase. The lesson program loses money every month, so she quietly sells a horse now and then to cover the gap — and tells herself that's just how it is.

It is not how it is. It is how it was taught to her. And the lie costs far more than money.

What the lie actually costs

It costs the owner her health and her years. It costs her family a present, rested parent and partner. And — this is the part our industry refuses to say out loud — **it costs the horses.** A barn with no margin can't fund the care it knows the horses deserve. It overworks the steady old lesson horse because there's no money to bring on a younger one and no plan to retire the elder with dignity. The unprofitable barn is not the ethical barn. It is the one most likely to let the horses down when it matters.

So let's name the lie precisely. It isn't that horses can't pay. It's that *this way of running a barn* can't pay. The good news hiding inside that sentence is enormous: if the problem is the model, the model can be changed.

The turning point is a decision, not a windfall

Before any tactic in this book will work, one thing has to shift, and it lives between your ears. I call it radical responsibility.

> ***If the business isn't working, the lever that can fix it is my own skill — not my town, not my clients, not the economy.***

This is not a guilt trip. It is the most hopeful idea I know, because it is the only one that puts the controls back in your hands. "Nobody in my area has $350 a month" is not a fact about your area; it is a fact about your current offer and the way you talk about it. "I can't find good help" is a hiring-and-leadership skill you haven't built yet. "People won't pay what I'm worth" is a pricing-and-positioning skill we will build together in a few chapters.

The moment you decide that every result in your business points back to a skill you can learn, you stop being a victim of the horse economy and start being its architect. That word — architect — is the whole book. We are going to draw the structure on purpose: a barn that puts horses first, pays you well, and is built to last. The next chapter starts where every honest plan in this industry has to start. Not with money. With the horses.

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CHAPTER TWO

Horse-First Is the Foundation, *Not the Sacrifice*

Every profit decision in your barn has to pass through the horses first. Not as a slogan — as a structural floor you build on.

People assume "horse-first" and "profitable" pull in opposite directions, so they pick a side and feel righteous about it. I am going to show you they are the same direction. But it only works if the welfare floor is real and explicit. Here are the four pillars I hold every barn to. Write them on the wall.

THE FOUR HORSE-FIRST PILLARS

1 · Usage. A lesson horse should work a sane, sustainable schedule. Pushing one well past about ten hours of lessons a week, or leaning hard on an aging horse, is a red flag — for the horse and, as you'll see, for your economics.

2 · Care. The budget must contain real, adequate line items for feed, farrier, and vet. If those numbers aren't in the plan, the plan is fiction.

3 · Retirement. Every horse has a documented exit plan: money set aside, a field set aside, or a sale into a vetted private home while the horse is still useful and wanted. No horse falls through the cracks.

4 · Education & Empathy. The school teaches that horses are sentient partners, not machines — and sends a generation of more thoughtful owners out into the world. That is our product as much as the riding is.

Notice what these pillars do. They aren't decoration on top of the business; they are constraints the business is engineered around. When we get to pricing and scheduling, every recommendation I make will already be inside these lines. That is what "architecture" means — the welfare is in the load-bearing walls, not the paint.

The hardest conversation in our industry

There is one objection I hear more than any other, and I have to meet it head-on, because it quietly destroys both barns and horses. It sounds noble:

> *"I would never sell my horses. I'm too ethical for that."*

I want to be gentle here, because the people who say this are usually big-hearted. But I owe you the truth more than I owe you comfort. Very often, "I'm too ethical to sell" is not ethics at all. It is financial helplessness wearing a halo.

Watch what actually happens under that banner. The owner makes no money, so she can't fund the care she's promising. She leans financially on a spouse until that relationship strains. She has nothing left — money, time, or energy — for her own children. And the horse she swore never to part with gets worked into his twenties anyway, because there was never a plan or the means to do anything else. That is not the moral high ground. That is the moral cost of being unprofitable, dressed up as virtue.

Here is the reframe, and I mean it with my whole chest: **loving a horse often means letting him go.** A sound, kind horse rehomed at fourteen into a good private home — more individual attention, lighter hours, one family who adores him — frequently gets a *better* life than the one who is held until he can't be responsibly placed and is worked because the barn can't afford otherwise. Selling well, at the right time, to the right home, is not a betrayal of the horse-first ethic. It is the horse-first ethic, executed by someone competent enough to fund it.

So I'll say it once, plainly, and then we'll go build the plan: you are not a better person for sacrificing profit in the name of welfare. The owners who can actually protect horses for a lifetime are the ones who learned to run a real business. Horse-first and profitable are not a compromise. They are the same skill. The next chapter turns that ethic into an actual operating pattern — the way a horse moves through a healthy barn over the years of his career.

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CHAPTER THREE

The Horse's Career: *A Lifecycle That Pays*

A healthy barn moves its horses through a deliberate lifecycle — and that lifecycle is good for the horse and good for the books at the same time.

Most schools acquire horses by accident and keep them by inertia. Then one day the owner looks up and realizes the whole program is being carried by animals who are all getting old together. Let me give you the pattern that prevents that, the way I'd teach it standing in your aisle.

The cycle that works

- **Acquire around age twelve.** Mature, trained, sane, with plenty of good working years ahead. You pay for the training someone else already put in — and that is money well spent.
- **Give two strong years to the program.** The horse earns his living teaching, inside the Usage pillar from the last chapter — a sustainable schedule, not a grind.
- **Rehome around age fourteen.** Sell him into a vetted private home where he gets more individual attention and lighter hours. This is a better life for him, a profit for you, and it frees a slot for a younger horse.
- **Repeat.** A barn that runs this cycle on purpose always has a herd weighted toward its prime years.

The cliff almost nobody plans for

There is a saleability cliff around age sixteen. Before it, a sound, kind horse has a market and a future you can hand him to with confidence. After it, that window closes fast — and now a sale isn't a graceful transition, it's a fire sale you'll rightly refuse to make. So the time to place a horse well is *before* the cliff, while he still has years a private owner will treasure. Hold past it without a plan, and you've taken the choice away from yourself.

How riding schools die quietly

I call the failure mode "the five twenty-year-olds." It happens to lovely, devoted owners. You acquire horses a little too old, you hold them a little too long because you love them, and one season you wake up with a herd that has all aged out at once. None can be responsibly sold. All need retirement at the same time. There is no exit, no liquidity, and the fixed costs — feed, farrier, vet, board — keep marching whether or not those horses can still teach. The barn doesn't fail in a dramatic crash. It bleeds out slowly under the weight of horses it can no longer fund or place.

> ***The most loving thing you can do for a horse is to still have the means to care for him. A planned lifecycle is how you keep that means.***

This is the Retirement pillar made concrete. Every horse moving through your barn should have a known next chapter before he needs it. One number tells you whether you're on track or drifting toward the cliff: the age distribution of your herd. We'll put it on the scoreboard in Chapter 8. For now, just start noticing it — walk your barn and ask how old everyone is, and whether they all got old together. With the welfare architecture in place, we can finally talk about money. The next chapter changes the way you see your entire business.

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CHAPTER FOUR

Think Like a *Capacity Business*

Your barn is not a store that can stock more shelves. It is a fixed footprint. Once you truly see that, your priorities reorder themselves.

A software company can sign a thousand new customers without building anything. You cannot. You have a fixed number of stalls, a fixed number of arenas, and — this is the one that matters most — a fixed number of *primetime hours* when real people can actually ride: after school, after work, and on weekends. Everything good in your business has to be produced inside that footprint. That single fact should drive nearly every decision you make.

The master number

Because the footprint is fixed, the question that runs the whole business is: **how much revenue is each stall producing per month?** Revenue per stall per month is the master number — the one I look at first in any barn. It quietly contains everything else. Are your horses earning their keep or standing around? Is your pricing right? Is primetime full? You don't have to ask those questions one at a time, because this number is downstream of all of them.

> **THE REFRAME**
>
> Don't ask, "How do I get more clients, more horses, more stuff?" Ask, "How do I get more value out of the footprint I already have?" The first question grows your costs. The second grows your profit.

Why this changes your instincts

Once you think in capacity, your instincts flip in healthy ways. Another horse is not automatically an asset — if it doesn't raise revenue per stall, it's a new mouth eating feed, farrier, and vet for no return. A spaced-out schedule of private lessons during your most valuable hours is not "premium service," it's empty shelves during the holiday rush. A second location is not the obvious next step when your first one is half-utilized; the cheapest growth you'll ever find is the empty primetime hour you already own.

Hold this lens up to everything that follows. Pricing, your choice of market, your schedule, your hiring — each one is really a question about how to fill a fixed footprint with the highest-quality, most durable revenue, without ever crossing the welfare floor we built in Chapters 2 and 3. We'll start with the lever that moves the master number fastest: what you charge, and how. That's next.

CHAPTER FIVE

Pricing That Respects *You and the Horse*

The single fastest way to change a barn's health is to change how it charges. Move from selling lessons one at a time to selling membership.

Most schools price like a vending machine: a client shows up, buys a lesson, maybe comes back. Revenue is a guess every month. There is no commitment in either direction, so the schedule is chaos and the cash flow is a heart monitor. I want to hand you something steadier, for you and for the horse.

The model that wins: membership with terms

Sell a monthly membership, not a punch card. A clean, common version looks like this:

> **A CORE MEMBERSHIP**
>
> *About $350 a month* for one weekly mounted lesson plus one weekly unmounted group horsemanship class.
>
> The member is enrolled in a program and pays monthly — whether or not they make it every single week — with fair, clearly written make-up terms. It is a relationship with reasonable expectations on both sides, not a transaction that restarts from zero every Tuesday.

That second class matters more than it looks. The unmounted horsemanship hour deepens the student's bond with horses (there's the Education pillar earning its keep), it builds better, safer riders, and it adds value the member feels without adding mounted hours to your horses. Good for the rider, good for the horse, good for the books.

Why pay-per-lesson is a slow death

Pay-per-lesson pricing punishes you for everything that goes right. You carry all the no-show risk. You can't plan a schedule because you don't know who's coming. You can't forecast, so you can't invest. And because every week is a fresh negotiation, your best clients drift away one polite skipped lesson at a time. Membership flips all of it: predictable revenue, a real schedule, a committed community, and the ability to plan your horses' work humanely because you know what the week holds.

The math that makes it obvious

Picture one good lesson horse working a sustainable schedule under ten hours a week — well inside the Usage pillar. Put eight to ten members on him through group lessons, and he can generate roughly **$2,800 to $3,500 a month.** That is more than most boarders pay — and the boarder also brings cleaning, turnout, and amenity overhead the lesson member doesn't. The membership horse, treated well and scheduled sanely, is very often the most productive and least demanding asset in your barn. This is what it looks like when horse-first and profitable turn out to be the same decision.

Moving your existing clients without a war

"But my current clients will revolt." They won't, if you do it gracefully. Build the new membership and launch it to *new* clients first, so it's proven and full before you touch anyone's loyalty. Grandfather your faithful long-timers — honor them; they earned it. Then, once the new offer is clearly working and new members are happily paying more than your legacy rates, give your existing clients a warm, no-pressure invitation to move up to the program. Some will, some won't, and that's fine. You are not yanking a rug; you are building a better house next door and leaving the door open. With pricing fixed, the next question is who you sell this to — and here most owners aim at exactly the wrong target.

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CHAPTER SIX

Stop Hunting *Unicorns*

Most owners chase the rarest, most contested client in the industry — and wonder why growth is so hard. The durable business is built on the opposite bet.

Here is the dream almost everyone in our world is sold: "I'll get twenty serious horse owners, each paying two thousand dollars a month for full training, and I'll be set." It sounds like the top of the mountain. It's actually a trap, and it's worth seeing exactly why.

Why the unicorn hunt fails

- **The pool is tiny and contested.** Serious full-training clients are rare, everyone wants them, and winning one often means quietly poaching from another barn — ethically uncomfortable and a small, bitter game.
- **It's dangerous concentration.** Twenty clients carrying your whole income means losing two or three can sink you. That's not a business; it's a high wire.
- **They want all of you, forever.** The premium client wants *you* every weekend, won't take your assistants, and ties your life to their show schedule. You haven't built a business; you've built a very expensive job with one demanding boss multiplied by twenty.

The needle-in-a-haystack reframe

Stop searching for the needle. Buy the haystack.

> ***Your ideal client isn't a rare unicorn. It's anyone with a body who could fall in love with horses.***

An excellent lesson program on good lesson horses, priced around $350 a month, is open to almost everyone. You could walk into a grocery store, tap a stranger on the shoulder, and they are a candidate. Fifty members is very achievable. A hundred or more is realistic for a well-run school. And because the base is broad, it is durable — losing a few members in a slow season is a ripple, not a crisis. A wide, recession-resistant membership base is the most stable foundation in this industry. It is also, quietly, the most ethical, because it is the one that can actually fund the horses for the long haul.

And here's the part the unicorn hunters miss

This isn't either/or. A big, healthy lesson program is the best possible source of those deeper clients. Out of fifty or a hundred members, a handful will fall hard for the sport and want more

— more lessons, a lease, eventually their own horse and real training. You develop them *in-house,* on a foundation you built and a culture they already trust. You get the premium relationships as a natural harvest of the broad base, instead of fighting for them in a thin, contested market. Build the haystack, and the needles grow inside it. Now let's make that footprint actually produce — by fixing your schedule and your herd.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

Fill Primetime, *Right-Size the Herd*

Three operational habits separate a profitable barn from an exhausting one: how you use your best hours, how many horses you keep, and what you pay people to do.

Primetime is for groups

Remember that your most valuable inventory is the handful of after-school, after-work, and weekend hours when people can actually ride. The mistake I see everywhere is filling those golden hours with private lessons spaced politely apart. It feels premium. It's money left on the ground.

Do the arithmetic. Four riders in a one-hour group is four lessons taught in one hour. The same four riders as back-to-back privates is two hours of your instructor's time for the same four lessons. Multiply that across a week and the gap is staggering:

> ***Twenty lessons taught in eleven hours is a thriving business. The same twenty lessons taught in twenty hours is a burnout.***

So the rule is simple: **primetime runs on back-to-back group lessons.** Reserve privates for off-peak hours or for the specific students who genuinely need them. This one change often lifts revenue per stall and gives the owner her evenings back at the same time.

Right-size the herd

More horses is not more business — it's more cost. Each lesson horse should be doing roughly eight to ten hours of lessons a week (right inside the Usage pillar), and you want about two spares for sickness, soundness, and rotation. Two. Not six.

A barn with ten lesson horses covering thirty lessons a week isn't well-stocked; it's badly under-utilized — every horse working three hours while you feed, shoe, and vet all ten. Those idle horses are dead capital that still eats every month. Size the herd to the lessons you actually teach, plus a sane buffer, and your revenue per stall climbs without a single new client. (And if "right-sizing" means placing a couple of horses, you already know from Chapter 3 how to do that well and early.)

The payroll rule

Here is a test that will keep your labor costs honest. Every person you pay should be doing one of two things: **teaching lessons, or cleaning and caring for the barn.** That's it. Those are the activities that serve horses and generate revenue.

This business does not support a tier of managers, and certainly not managers of managers. The instant you're paying someone to oversee the people who do the actual work, your math breaks — you've added cost without adding a single taught lesson or a single clean stall. Keep your team on the floor and in the saddle, pack your instructors' hours with groups, and your payroll stays a fraction of what it would be in a top-heavy operation. With the welfare, the pricing, the market, and the operations set, it's time to put a dashboard on all of it.

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CHAPTER EIGHT

Run It by *the Numbers*

You cannot fix what you cannot see. A handful of numbers, checked weekly, turn your barn from a source of anxiety into a cockpit you can actually fly.

You don't need accounting software you'll never open or a forty-tab spreadsheet. You need a small, honest scoreboard you look at every week — ideally the same morning each week, coffee in hand. Here are the numbers that matter and the simple traffic-light read I use for each.

What to watch	Why it matters	The quick read
Revenue per stall / month	The master number from Chapter 4 — is your footprint producing?	● strong ● soft ● low
Subscription % of revenue	How much of your income is committed membership vs. one-off lessons.	● mostly recurring ● pay-per-lesson trap
Lesson-horse utilization	Hours each horse teaches per week — too low wastes capital, too high crosses the Usage pillar.	● 8–10 hrs ● 5–8 ● under 5 or over 12
Spare-horse count	Buffer beyond your working herd — more than a couple is dead weight.	● two or fewer ● five or more
Primetime group %	Are your best hours running on groups or leaking into privates?	● mostly groups ● private-heavy
Off-the-floor headcount	People you pay who neither teach nor clean (the payroll rule).	● zero or one ● a growing tier
Herd age distribution	From Chapter 3 — are your horses weighted young, or aging out together?	● weighted to prime ● cluster past 16, no plan
Monthly churn	The share of members who cancel each month — the silent killer.	● low and stable ● creeping up

Churn deserves its own paragraph

Most owners obsess over new members and never look at the back door. But a barn losing members faster than it can replace them is running up a down escalator, and the spreadsheet at the top can still look fine while the leak gets worse. Watch churn like a hawk. Better still, get ahead of it: a member whose payment just failed, who's missed two lessons in a row, or whose child seems to be drifting is telling you something *before* they cancel. A quick, warm call from the trainer at that moment saves memberships that a month later would already be gone. Saving a member is far cheaper than winning a new one.

None of this has to be a chore. The whole point of a scoreboard is calm — you glance at it, you see green, yellow, and red, and you put your attention exactly where it's needed instead of worrying about everything at once. (This is, in fact, the part of the work I'm building software to do automatically, watching these numbers for you in the background — but that's a story for the end of the book.) With the cockpit built, let's talk about the one input that fills every other number: a steady flow of new riders.

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CHAPTER NINE

A Predictable Way to *Fill Your Lessons*

Growth stops being a mystery when you see it as a path with clear steps — and when you stop ignoring the goldmine you already own.

I'm not going to hand you a hundred clever tactics. Tactics change. The path doesn't. Every new member arrives by walking the same few steps, and your job is to make each step a little smoother.

The path

1. **Attention.** A stranger who could love horses notices you exist.
2. **A real conversation.** That attention turns into an actual back-and-forth — a message, a call, a reply — not a form that vanishes into a void.
3. **A paid intro lesson.** They come ride. A modest paid evaluation — around $75 — filters for real intent and lets your program do what it does best: create a horse person.
4. **A membership.** The great intro experience earns the invitation to join the program from Chapter 5.

That's the whole engine. When growth feels stuck, it's almost always one specific step leaking, and naming the step tells you where to work — not enough attention, conversations that fizzle, intros that don't get booked, or intros that don't convert. Fix the leaking step, not your whole life.

The goldmine you already own

Before you spend a dollar chasing new strangers, mine the list you already have. It is the cheapest growth in this business and almost everyone neglects it:

- People who once inquired and never booked.
- Members who lapsed — life got busy, and they'd come back if you simply, warmly asked.
- Your current members' friends and families, invited through a genuine referral ask.

These people already know you. Reaching back out to them, kindly and specifically, routinely fills more lessons than a cold campaign ever will — and it costs you a few hours, not a marketing budget.

Two principles that decide everything

Speed. When a new person raises a hand, the clock is brutal. Reply in minutes, not days. Interest cools fast, and the barn that answers first usually wins the rider — no matter who has the fancier facility.

Don't depend on one channel. If your entire pipeline runs through a single ad account, you are one algorithm change away from a very quiet month. Layer in your community — 4-H, Pony Club, scout troops, churches, schools — and a real referral habit among your members. A barn fed from several streams is a barn that sleeps at night.

This is the one area where I'll be a little protective of the deeper playbook — the exact sequences and the way to run all of this on autopilot are the heart of what I'm building into software, and I'd rather my clients keep that edge. But the principles above are yours, free, and they're enough to change your year. Now, the chapter that turns a good income into lasting wealth — and protects everything you've built.

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CHAPTER TEN

Keep What You Make: *The CFP + EA Playbook*

Making money is half the job. Keeping it — protecting it from lawsuits and taxes, and turning it into real wealth — is the half almost no one in our industry is taught.

This is the chapter where my other two hats matter. As a CERTIFIED FINANCIAL PLANNER™ professional and an Enrolled Agent, I spend as much time on protection and wealth as I do on revenue. And I'll be honest with you: a riding school is one of the more dangerous, under-protected, and over-taxed small businesses there is. Horses, children, and parents on your property, day after day, is real risk. Most owners are exposed in ways that would keep them up at night if they understood them. Let's fix that — at a high level here, and then properly with your own advisors.

> **READ THIS FIRST**
>
> What follows is education, not personalized advice. Entity, insurance, and tax choices depend on your state, your numbers, and your family. Use this to ask your attorney, your insurance agent, and your tax professional far better questions — and find advisors who'll work together.

Structure: don't let one bad day reach the farm

The most important protection move is also the most overlooked: separate the things that can be sued from the things you can't bear to lose. In plain terms, the business that operates the lessons and the real estate that the barn sits on usually shouldn't be the same legal entity. Structured properly — typically with the operating company separate from the property — a lawsuit against the riding operation has a much harder time reaching the land, the house, and your savings. Get this designed once, correctly, and it quietly protects you for decades.

Insurance: find the gaps before they find you

Walk your coverage with a sharp agent and look specifically for the gaps that sink horse businesses:

- **Equine commercial liability** at limits that match today's reality, not a policy you bought years ago.
- **Care, custody, and control** — coverage for the client-owned horses in your care, which standard policies often exclude.
- **Premises liability** for everyone who sets foot on the property.
- **An umbrella policy** sitting above it all for the catastrophic claim.

- **Workers' compensation** wherever you have employees.

Most barns are simultaneously over-insured on trivia and dangerously under-insured on the one claim that could end them. A gap review is cheap. The gap is not.

Tax: stop overpaying by accident

This is where the EA in me gets animated, because owners overpay tax every single year for lack of a plan. The right entity election can change your tax bill meaningfully. Your horses and your equipment can often be depreciated — and provisions like Section 179 can accelerate that. The administrative side of your business may support a legitimate home-office deduction and mileage. And the retirement vehicles below aren't just wealth-building; the contributions are frequently deductible. None of this is exotic. It is simply planned for on purpose, before year-end, instead of discovered in April.

Wealth: the business is the vehicle

Here's the mindset shift that changes everything: your barn isn't just your income, it's the engine for your net worth. A profitable school can fund serious, tax-advantaged retirement saving — a SEP-IRA or a Solo 401(k), and for high-earning owners even a defined-benefit plan that allows large deductible contributions. Pay yourself first by routing a fixed slice of profit into these accounts before it disappears into the next "must-have." Over the years, that discipline — not a windfall — is what turns a working owner into a wealthy one.

Track net worth, not just profit

Finally, measure the right scoreboard. Most owners, if they track anything, track whether the barn made money this month. I want you watching something bigger: your net worth climbing year over year — the business equity, the retirement accounts, the protected assets, all of it. The goal was never "the school is profitable." The goal is "I am becoming genuinely wealthy *and* protected *and* still horse-first." That is the whole promise of this book, on one line. The last short chapter is about how to actually make all of this happen — starting Monday.

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Operating System: *Ready, Fire, Aim*

A method only matters if you run it. These four principles are how change actually happens — and they're how I'd have you start this week.

The four principles

Ready, Fire, Aim. Ship a rough version into the real world and improve it from real feedback. The owners who fail spend three years perfecting a curriculum, a website, a plan — in private, where it can't teach them anything. Launch the imperfect thing. The market will tell you more in two weeks than two years of planning ever could.

The scientific method. Drop the words "good" and "bad." You have a current state, you take an action, you read the feedback, you adjust, and now you have a new state. That's it. A price that didn't land isn't a failure and you aren't a fraud — it's data, and data is exactly what you needed. This mindset removes the shame that keeps owners frozen.

Responsibility. We started here, and we end here. Every result points back to a skill you can build. That's not a burden; it's your power, because it means nothing important is outside your control.

Focus. Sunlight feels warm. Sunlight through a magnifying glass starts a fire. The difference is concentration. Pick the one thing that matters most right now and pour yourself into it, rather than dabbling at ten and igniting none.

Your first ninety days

Don't try to do this whole book at once — that's the opposite of focus. Here's a calm order that works:

1. **Weeks 1–2 — Steady the welfare floor.** Walk the four pillars. Check every horse's hours, the care line items in your budget, and whether each horse has a known next chapter. Fix anything urgent.
2. **Weeks 2–4 — Switch to membership and auto-pay.** Build the core membership from Chapter 5 and get new clients onto automatic monthly payment. This alone steadies your cash flow.
3. **Weeks 4–6 — Fill primetime with groups.** Rebuild your best hours around back-to-back group lessons and right-size the herd as you go.
4. **Weeks 6–8 — Install the scoreboard.** Start your weekly numbers ritual. You can't steer what you don't measure.
5. **Weeks 8–12 — Turn on demand.** Reactivate your own list first, then build a couple of steady channels, answering every new lead in minutes.

Through all of it, run loose with welfare and tight with the architecture: never cross the floor in Chapters 2 and 3, and let the numbers — not your fears — tell you what's working. Do this and within a season you will have a barn that looks and feels different: calmer, fuller, and finally paying you back. There's one more thing I want to share with you before you go.

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IN CLOSING

Where This *Is Going*

If you run the method in this book, here's the barn you're walking toward: horse-first, genuinely profitable, properly protected, and quietly building you real wealth.

That's the whole promise — the welfare floor that never moves, the pricing and capacity discipline that finally pays you, the numbers that keep you calm, and the protection and planning that turn a good year into a good life. It's a lot to hold. So I'll tell you where I'm taking all of this next.

The system I'm building

Everything in these pages — the scoreboard, the welfare checks, the pricing model, the way you fill your lessons — I am building into software. It's called **Impulsion.io**. The simplest way to describe it: it watches your real numbers and coaches you in real time, in my voice and with this method, so you're never flying blind and never alone with the decision. Think of it as this book, awake and looking over your shoulder — keeping you horse-first while it helps you grow. I'm keeping the deeper mechanics close to the chest for now, but I wanted you to know it's coming, and that the principles you just read are its foundation.

An invitation

This is also why I'm doing something a little unusual: filming a small number of barns and rebuilding their businesses, on camera, with this exact method — and building an early-access list for the people who want in first. If reading this lit something up in you — if you've been grinding alone and you're ready for the version of this where someone competent is in your corner — I'd genuinely love to hear from you. Put your hand up. Tell me about your barn. The worst case is a useful conversation; the best case is the turning point you've been waiting for.

Whatever you do next, do this: decide, today, that horse-first and profitable were never opposites. Then go build the barn that proves it.

— Brian

About the Author

Brian Sean Wee, CFP, EA is the founder of **Next Level Horse Businesses**, where he and his team have helped more than a thousand riding schools become horse-first and profitable. He is a CERTIFIED FINANCIAL PLANNER™ professional and an IRS Enrolled Agent, which lets him work with owners on the whole picture — the horses, the profit-and-loss, the risk, and the family balance sheet — all at once. He is currently building **Impulsion.io**, software that brings this method to riding-school owners as an always-on business coach.

To learn more, or to put your barn forward, visit **impulsion.io**.